

Why do we do it? Because we want to feel important on the job. We want work to give us a sense of fulfillment. At times it does. But research shows it doesn't happen very often.

RIDING THE JOB IS RIDING A LOSING HORSE

In 1978 *Psychology Today* polled its readers about their jobs. *Psychology Today* readers are more highly educated, professional, and better paid than the national average. The 23,000 readers who responded said that the five most important aspects of their jobs were:

1. The chance to do something that makes you feel good about yourself
2. The chance to accomplish something worthwhile
3. The chance to learn new things
4. The chance to develop your skills and abilities
5. The amount of freedom you have on your job

Unfortunately, what we want out of our jobs and what we get from them are two different things. Thomas J. Peters and Robert H. Waterman, Jr., wrote the bestseller *In Search of Excellence* (Harper & Row, 1984) about American companies. They found that most of us "desperately need meaning in our lives and will sacrifice a great deal to institutions that will provide it to us." But Peters and Waterman concluded that the infrastructure of most American companies is almost consistently unable to provide meaning or any sense of worth to its employees.

One interesting side of being an auditor is that you get to peek into other people's business. I got an inside look at well-managed companies and not-so-well-managed companies. I toured big plants and small plants. I saw healthy balance sheets and sick ones. I saw top managers, middle managers, and people who just played at managing. Many of